TOPIC 3
Creating inclusive, equal and respectful relationships

3.1 Overview

3.1.1 Introduction

Relationships are a major part of your life; it is important that you develop relationships that are inclusive, equal and respectful. You need to practise a variety of skills such as empathy and active listening in order to nurture such relationships.

Other relationship skills include conflict resolution, negotiating consent, seeking help, providing feedback and asserting a stance in various situations. At times you may need to use these skills to help others.

You may sometimes encounter disrespectful relationships, which may affect you or someone you are close to. Disrespectful relationships may involve abuse, such as in the case of domestic violence situations. You need to have knowledge of and adopt protective practices when exposed to these relationships, ensuring that you are able to take control to keep yourself and others safe.

Everybody needs inclusive, equal and respectful relationships in their lives.



Supporting others, promoting diversity and being aware of and avoiding discriminatory practices are all important factors in building and maintaining relationships that are inclusive, equal and respectful.

on Resources

eLesson: Creating inclusive, equal and respectful relationships (eles-2965)

Digital doc: Key terms glossary (doc-29316)

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How can we create inclusive, equal and respectful relationships for ourselves and others?

SYLLABUS OUTCOMES

A student:

- assesses their own and others' capacity to reflect on and respond positively to challenges (PD5-1)
- analyses factors and strategies that enhance inclusivity, equality and respectful relationships (PD5-3)
- assesses and applies self-management skills to effectively manage complex situations (PD5-9)
- critiques their ability to enact interpersonal skills to build and maintain respectful and inclusive relationships in a variety of groups or contexts. (PD5-10)

3.2 Relationships

Your relationships are important components of your life. They help influence who you are and who you will become. During your life you will have many different relationships, from family, friends, peers, work colleagues and intimate relationships such as boyfriends/girlfriends. You need relationships to help fulfil your social, intellectual, spiritual, emotional and physical needs. There are a variety of interpersonal skills such as empathy and communication which are required to create **inclusive**, equal and respectful relationships.

3.2.1 What is a relationship?

Relationships are associations or attachments formed either by choice (school friends, neighbours, teammates) or because you are part of a family (siblings, parents and other relatives). Relationships exist between all sorts of people, such as mother and child, brother and sister, and girlfriend and boyfriend. As we mature, we place different importance on interactions with some people and our relationships change.

Relationships serve many purposes and may fulfil one or more of our social, intellectual, spiritual, emotional or physical needs. Depending on whether the relationship is with a family member, a partner, a teacher, a neighbour or someone else, these needs will vary.



3.2.2 Components of inclusive and equal relationships

In order for a relationship to be inclusive and equal, all parties within the relationship need to feel included and supported. Thoughts, feelings and ideas need to be considered equally as everyone has a role to play in developing and maintaining the relationship.

Some components of inclusive, equal and respectful relationships include respect, trust, honesty, equality, safety, consistency and empathy.

Empathy

Empathy is the ability to relate to or identify with another person's feelings or situation — to be able to 'put yourself in someone else's shoes'. Empathy helps strengthen relationships and creates openness between people — it is a key tool in relationships. When empathy is absent, there is likely to be less consideration of each other's needs and feelings in the relationship; when it is present, people feel listened to and understood.

Empathy is important in supporting the balance of power between two people. Listening to the other person and allowing them to express their thoughts and feelings will help you understand how that person is feeling. This can help you also understand how your behaviour might affect them. You can then adapt your behaviour so you both feel valued and supported.

3.2.3 Relationship expectations

Everyone has the right to feel safe, to be treated with fairness, to be valued and to feel accepted for who they are. Respectful relationships are important because they contribute to your growth and sense of self-confidence; they promote healthy self-expression and awareness of yourself and others, and they enable you to feel accepted and free to be yourself.

Being in a respectful relationship doesn't mean that you won't have differences of opinion or disagreements. However, in respectful relationships when differences occur they are dealt with in ways that lead to a resolution or understanding. Conflict or differences occurring in respectful relationships can be worked out and do not have to damage the relationship.

Everyone needs people they can trust and communicate with.



People can have different expectations and needs in a relationship and can show their feelings in different ways. These expectations may affect their interactions. We need to recognise our different needs, reactions and expectations when in a relationship. **Communication**, empathy and active listening are essential. Communicating our expectations and feelings allows the relationship to be an effective and supportive one.

How we behave in certain relationships can determine whether we have a healthy, balanced relationship or not. Complete the **Behavioural expectations in relationships** worksheet in the Resources tab to explore the behaviours expected by individuals in different relationships.

on Resources

Digital doc: Worksheet 3.1 Behavioural expectations in relationships (doc-29307)

DID YOU KNOW?

Research shows spending time with friends and family can increase your life expectancy. The more positive relationships a person has, the more likely he or she will enjoy a healthy lifestyle.

3.2.4 Influences on relationships

There are many influences on our relationships, which may be positive or negative. These influences include our family, friends, peer groups, intimate relationships, religion, gender and sexuality.

Family

When you are young, getting on with your parents can sometimes be a challenge. As you form your own personal identity, you may think differently from your parents and have different values and beliefs, which can lead to conflict at home or breakdowns in communication. As a teenager you want to be more independent and think and speak for yourself. This can be hard for parents to get used to. Parents can continue to be protective of you and want to influence what you do and how you do it. Ultimately this is because they want what is best for you, but this can sometimes feel overbearing.

Family can influence us in many ways.



Friends

Friendships we establish are usually based on common interests, such as hobbies and sports. Similarly, friends may drift apart because their interests and situations change and there is less to talk about or they have less in common. This situation is not necessarily negative; it shows that individuals are maturing and reassessing their interests.

We gain much support and confidence from friendships that are positive, enduring and meaningful. Loyalty, trust, respect, confidentiality, equity, acceptance, empathy and understanding are components of sound and ongoing friendships. We share fun, experiences, humour and memories with our friends. Even when situations occur that challenge the strength of a friendship, there is sufficient depth and support to enable it to survive. We find it easy to defend our friends when the bond of friendship is strong and intact. However, friendships are dynamic, and things change over time or as a result of circumstances. Friendships don't just happen; they must be worked on.

Just as a friendship can be a rewarding part of life, life can also be stressful when the friendship starts to falter. We may feel anxious, guilty, hurt or even jealous at these times. Not all friendships are healthy. Some friendships can be destructive, especially if people have different values or become too dependent on their friends. Negative peer pressure can influence decision-making and impact on the lives of all involved.

Anger and resentment are common negative feelings we encounter when friendships unexpectedly fall apart. It is difficult to remain objective and separate the problem from the person in these situations. We need to think carefully about the *reasons* behind the breakdown and work out ways to restore the friendship or, as painlessly as possible, to continue without that person in our life. Often, a lack of communication — the inability to listen to and be honest with friends — causes breakdowns in a friendship.

A lack of communication may cause a breakdown in a friendship.



Are you a good friend? Use the **What kind of friend are you?** and **Making friends** weblinks in the Resources tab to take a quiz and assess what type of friend you are. How accurate do you believe these kinds of quizzes are? What might be a better indication of your friendship skills? Think of ten characteristics you believe a good friend should have.

Resources

Weblink: What kind of friend are you?
Weblink: Making friends

Peer groups

A **peer group** is a group of people who are roughly the same age as you and are from a similar background. We tend to relate well to our peers because of these two factors and we value their comments and attitudes. A peer group can be an influential and powerful aspect of our lives.

Belonging to a peer group has many benefits. We can feel secure and confident in the knowledge that our peers will assist us, accept us and support us through thick and thin. We trust the members of the group and experience enjoyment through the activities we have in common and the personal qualities we appreciate in each other.

Peer groups exert pressure because belonging is an important human need.



Sometimes there is a leader who directs the group, perhaps subtly, into 'acceptable' activities and behaviours. If this leader is well respected or asserts power in certain ways, then it is likely that the rest of the group will follow their actions. If members of the group are doubtful about becoming involved in any activity, then tension or conflict may develop within the group. This can become a very difficult and stressful situation, where group members need to make decisions regarding the appropriateness of the activity. Pressure from the leader or other group members may add to the dilemma of individuals trying to make sound decisions.

There are times when you may feel pressured by your peer group into doing something with which you are uncomfortable, but you may also feel the desire to still be accepted and part of the group. The decision about what to do will depend upon the strength of your own convictions, personal confidence and assertiveness. Family and/or cultural expectations and perhaps a sense of moral obligation may also play a role. The combination of these factors will lead you to a decision.

Intimate relationships

A relationship with a very close friend is an **intimate relationship**. There is a high level of sharing, trust, affection, understanding and personal disclosure of information in such a relationship. Sexual attraction may also be a feature. **Sexual activity** or intercourse may form part of an intimate relationship, but you can have intimacy without being physically intimate.

Affection can be shown in many ways.



Religion

Religion can influence inclusivity, equality and respect within relationships. If we are connected to a particular religion, the particular values and beliefs may influence how we interact with others. Some religions have certain values relating to the rights and responsibilities within relationships. For example, many religions place importance on a couple marrying before living together or having children.

Gender

Existing gender stereotypes may influence the inclusivity, equality and respect within relationships. Ideas about how males and females are supposed to act may impact certain behaviours. For example, males are often stereotyped as being less communicative about their thoughts and feelings than females are, which may place pressure on females to be the main communicator in the relationship. In respectful relationships, both males and females need to be open communicators and play equal roles in order to ensure that both parties' needs are understood and met.

Sexuality

Sexuality refers to who we are attracted to, whether this be males and/or females. It is important that we respect and support our friends and family members regardless of their sexuality. Inclusivity and equal treatment is important in supporting and fostering respectful relationships.

Every relationship in your life should be respectful.



3.2.5 Rights and responsibilities in relationships

Positive and respectful relationships are built on equality, respect and accountability. Each individual in a relationship has both rights and responsibilities. In any relationship you have the right to express your feelings and opinions, make decisions about yourself and have equal decision-making power, and feel safe and supported. In any relationship you have the responsibility to respect the other person's values, feelings and beliefs, communicate clearly and honestly, compromise and be considerate.

People in respectful relationships acknowledge that others may have a different view to them. Decisions and actions may differ between people. Have you ever known someone that changed their mind after they made a particular decision that also affected you? How did it make you feel? Have you ever made a decision and then changed your mind?

Complete the **Relationships — rights and responsibilities** worksheet in the Resources tab to explore what rights you have in certain relationships, and the responsibilities you need to deliver to others in those relationships.